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Losing Language

The first time I ever lost my language I was sitting outside, in the middle of the morning, working on math homework. Working with numbers on a screen, I had no idea I would not be able to speak, read, or even think with the full vocabulary I was accustomed to; the only clue I had was for some reason numbers were disappearing from my vision when I looked at them wrong. I remember walking inside, going through the kitchen and finding my mom in the living room. I tried to tell her about what was going on with my vision, but was surprised (and quite scared) to find that instead of the words I wanted to say, coming out of my mouth was gibberish, with maybe the hint of one or two actual words.

Rushing to my room I grabbed a book, and, running back out to the living room I discovered along with gibberish coming out from my mouth, gibberish was also coming in through my eyes; I could no longer recognize any of the words on the page, or even begin to try pronouncing them.

Although later I would come to enjoy and even wish for more of this experience, at the time it was possibly one of the most terrifying things I ever went through. I was 100% sure I was having a stroke and thought I would never be able to speak or read properly again. Sitting in the E.R. I remember racking my brain, trying to feel out “damage”, searching desperately for how I would continue to live without the majority of my language. Through this

process of finding what I could still do, I started to realize two things: how vital language was for my life (I use it constantly, both for things necessary and for most things fun), and that places existed where it was not as vital or necessary as I had previously thought.

I first began to have complex migraines (now called migraines with aura) a few years ago, right before I started high school. A complex migraine is generally a migraine with an aura phase containing stroke-like symptoms before the pain of the migraine phase.

While this first was perhaps the most dramatic, I continued to have complex migraines (and still do) although they appeared quite infrequently, and with almost no rhyme or reason. However for the rest, unlike the first, I knew what I was dealing with, and instead of terrifying losses of language they became exciting moments of freedom from it, which helped me grow into how I use language now.

One of these later migraines I distinctly remember, as it helped me deepen my understanding of my relationship between language and thought.

I was outside, barefoot, and up in a pine tree when I began to notice one of the antennas on some roof seemed to be flickering in and out of reality. This threw me for a bit, before I realized what was going on and recognized I was having another complex migraine. While the prospects of the migraine part were not something I looked forward too, at the moment I was mostly excited for the “complex” part. As it was, I decided up in a tree was not the best place to experience disappearances in my vision, and as I prepared myself to explore my mind I made my way down the tree. As I climbed down, my language began to disappear. Despite this, I found myself still able to

think and picture things clearly; I conjured up images, remixed memories, and connected them all with metaphor. I soon realized though, all these images and thoughts, without language, were being washed away, like sticks and leaves in a storm. Seeing this led me to believe that language was like the scaffolding that holds ideas in place and fixes them there, and not necessarily the thing that helps them form or even makes them up (although it can be). Later on, this image would join hands with another and help me use language as freely as I want to, without all the constraints it (or I) impose.

As these migraines continued to pop up ever so infrequently, I made my way into high school, and took some of what I consider my first “real” writing courses, in this case, AP Language & Composition. At this point I had taken a few writing classes before and could tell that the major struggle for me was the actual use of language itself; I felt I had to write only “A” quality work or it wasn’t worth it (even though I knew otherwise), and would often get hung up in the very first steps of writing a draft and idea generation. I had a few strategies to get around this (primarily changing the medium, e.g. writing with a dip pen), but they were not always consistent.

One such time I (mostly) clearly remember, I was working on a short essay talking about the book “Foundation” by Isaac Asimov, and I was getting nowhere. Although I knew I had some ideas in my head, I could not get them out; I was too focused on getting the language and structure just right. Eventually, I had a sort of epiphany (although the true realization came after), and almost completely gave up on writing with “real” language and structure. I knew that language gives ideas structure but this structure was also exactly what was giving me trouble, it needed the words to be exact

and precise. So I tried using the most basic structure I knew, and let my words just leave breadcrumbs, tracking my ideas as I made my way through them. Minimizing the language I used, to maximize my ideas and the speed with which I illuminated them. Like I was painting with watercolor, filling in broad strokes, rather than using a fine-tip pen, filling in all the small details and getting all the lines to connect *just* right. Eventually, I had a very crude pseudo-list of “sentences”, with only the most basic relations. But that very crude structure contained most of my idea and let me see it all at once and rework it into something much better.

As I continued to live and think and write, and my skill with language continued to grow, I also worked to retain and improve my skill without language, or more specifically my skill at thinking without language. While it may have first sprung from my complex migraines and flexed its muscles for the first time thinking about language, it became another tool I use as I move through the world, just like language.

Through all of these experiences I was able to see past the empire of language, and into the lands beyond. Having this access and view helped me see my own language and how *I* use it, especially in academic contexts where I to struggle with perfectionism. Being able to see that languages was not all consuming almost allowed me to break through those barriers of perfectionism I had constructed and I could side-step the problem of only trying to write the perfect combinations of words by avoiding words entirely while blocking out ideas.